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The Road DOWNHILL

Mount Abu falls prey to greed and laws being bent as another hill station bites the dust

By Rohit Parihar

It is a familiar saga, from Shimla to Mussoorie and now Mount Abu. The only hill station in Rajasthan with a beautiful lake that attracts 18 lakh tourists a year, has seen a spurt in corruption, illegal constructions, painful demolitions and harassment of commoners in the past few years after a Supreme Court order banned construction in the hill city. Paradoxically, it was a signal for haphazard construction as orders were flouted openly. When the dust settled, the Rajasthan Government held as many as 92 officials guilty—including the commissioner of the municipal-

ity—and suspended six in September, for aiding in illegal construction among other crimes. Residents of the 25,000-strong town, however, say some top officials who were actually responsible for supervision and allegedly connived with bribe givers have been left untouched.

The 2002 Supreme Court order banned “further building plans or construction” in Mount Abu until it was declared an eco-sensitive zone. Tragically, as many as 600 cases of violation of the order have been recorded since—86 in the last year and 77 cases up to September this year, officially. Unofficially the figures are much higher. The past 18 months saw

a spurt as local politicians and officials connived to take advantage of laxity due to Assembly polls in December 2008 and Lok Sabha polls this year.

The State Government reacted belatedly and the anti-corruption department launched investigations. The rot was deep-rooted. Two of its officials were transferred out of Sirohi district in which Mount Abu falls, at the behest of the builder lobbies. The cover-up continued till reports reached the chief minister’s office, which then launched an independent investigation later this year. Demolitions were then resorted to mainly as tokenism to prove that something was being done about the issue. In fact, the same set of corrupt officials went about conducting token demolitions, bringing down or leaving intact structures or portions according to the bribe paying capacity of the violators.

The sorry saga started when A.K. Sharma, a Mount Abu-based physician, signed an application in an ongoing case that ultimately resulted in the setting up of an empowered committee on environment charged with responsibility to balance environment with development. Says Sharma: “Many times I regret whether I was right in